CLARK · BETA · FOR MAC

Getting started with clark



Meet clark.

Keep one project record. Shape the weekly report from it. Publish it.

clark is a report editor for programme managers. It keeps a project's actions, risks, issues, decisions, milestones and use cases in one place on your own computer, with a history and Undo.

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1 What you need

- A Mac. Windows and Linux downloads come later.
- Google Chrome.
- Python 3.9 or newer. Your Mac may already have it. The check in the next part tells you.
- Docker is optional. It is for a Mac that will not open clark.command, or if you already use Docker.

Your data stays on your computer. It goes only where you send it: a published report, an Excel or Word file you save, a backup folder you choose, or, when you ask clark a question, the passages it needs go to the Claude or ChatGPT you connected.

2 Install and first start

Unzip the download: you get one folder called clark.

To check your Mac is ready, open Terminal in the clark folder and type bash clark.command --check. It tells you what to fix, if anything, and where to get it.

```
bash clark.command --check
```

Open clark

Without Docker:

1. Double-click clark.command in this folder.

2. The first time, your Mac may say it could not verify clark.command and offer only Move to Trash and Done. This is expected, not a fault. Do not choose Move to Trash: choose Done. Then open System Settings, choose Privacy & Security, scroll down and choose Open Anyway beside clark.command, then double-click it again. On a computer your employer manages, Open Anyway may ask for an administrator's password, and your employer may not allow it. If you cannot get past it, use the typed way below, which needs no password.
3. A Terminal window starts clark, then its window opens in Chrome (or in your usual browser if Chrome isn't there).
4. After a while with no window open, clark stops by itself. To use it again, double-click the file again.

Double-clicking while clark is open just opens another window.

The typed way: open Terminal, type cd and a space, drag this folder into the Terminal window and press Return. Then type:

```
bash clark.command
```

and press Return. Use this too if double-clicking does nothing.

Or use Docker

If your Mac will not open clark.command (a work Mac often will not), or you already use Docker, use Docker instead. You only need Docker and Chrome.

1. Open Docker Desktop and wait until it says it is running.
2. Open Terminal, type cd and a space, drag this folder into the Terminal window and press Return.
3. Type this and press Return (the first time it takes a few minutes):

   ```
   docker compose -f docker/compose.yaml up -d
   ```
4. Open Chrome and go to http://localhost:8766
5. To stop clark, type this in the same folder and press Return:

   ```
   docker compose -f docker/compose.yaml down
   ```

Use the clark download, not a copy of the source code: a copy of the source has no built page, and Docker stops with a message saying so. Start Docker from the clark folder.

3 Demo data

The first time clark opens a new data folder, it shows made-up demo projects, with a banner that reads “This is demo data.” Press Remove demo data to take them away. Your own projects are not touched, and a safety copy is made first. To look around with a separate set that is never kept, open Terminal in the clark folder and type:

```
bash clark.command --demo --open
```

Nothing you do there is kept.

4 Your first five things

These five jobs cover a first week with clark. The steps are the same as the ones in clark's own Help, which you can open at any time.

Add a work item

Put a new task on the plan and say who owns it.

1. On **Work items**, press the **+** at the top right. Point at it and it shows what it adds, following the type switch: **Add action**, **Add decision**, **Add risk or issue** (a menu of Risk and Issue) and, on All, **Add item** (a menu of Action, Risk, Issue and Decision). You can do this in View as well as in Edit.
2. The new item is made at once and opens in the peek with its title selected: type over it. A message at the foot of the page says it was added, with **Undo**.
3. Its due date (a week from today; a decision's needed-by date is today), and an action's priority, are placeholders. Change them in the list or in the peek.
4. A new item is shown to the client to start with. While one still has its placeholder title, the Publish box warns you. Rename it, or turn off its eye, before you publish.
5. In Edit on the Dashboard, the last row of each list adds one too: type "Owner: what it is" (the owner, a colon, then what it is) and press `Enter`.

Write this week's report

Fill in the status, the highlights and the next steps.

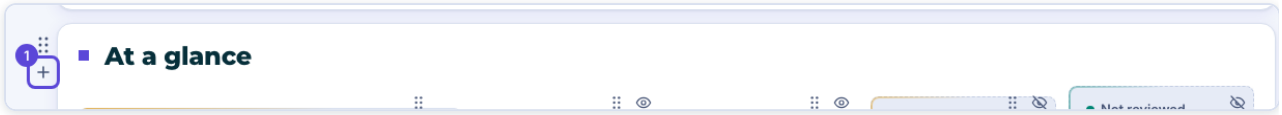
1. Open the **Dashboard** and press **Edit** at the top. Each change saves on its own.
2. Set **Week ending** to the Friday the report covers: type it as DD-MM-YYYY, or press `Enter` in the empty box to use the Friday shown. Any other day is not accepted.
3. Click the text under **Current state** and write where the project stands. It turns into an editor where it is: there is no Save button. Click away or press `Cmd+Enter` to keep it; `Esc` puts the old text back. Write the Summary, This week and Next week sections the same way.
4. Set the health on the **Project health** tile: see Set the project health in Help.
5. Check the lists of risks and issues, open actions and decisions. Click any part of a row (the state, the title, the owner, the date) to change it there; the ID opens the whole item in the peek.
6. Press **View** to read the report as the client will.

Add a section from a template

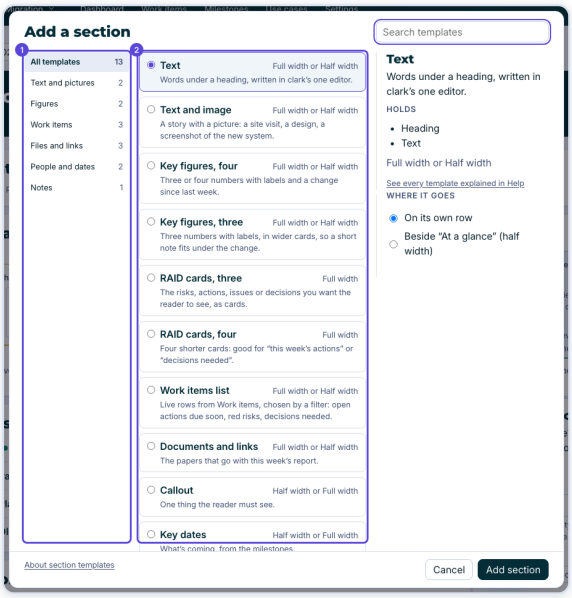
Start a new section from a layout, in the place you choose.

1. On the **Dashboard**, press **Edit**. Each section now has a control at the left of its card: a move button and, under it, a **+**.

2. Point at the section you want the new one to follow and press its **+**. Or click the move button to open the section's menu and choose **Add a template below…**.

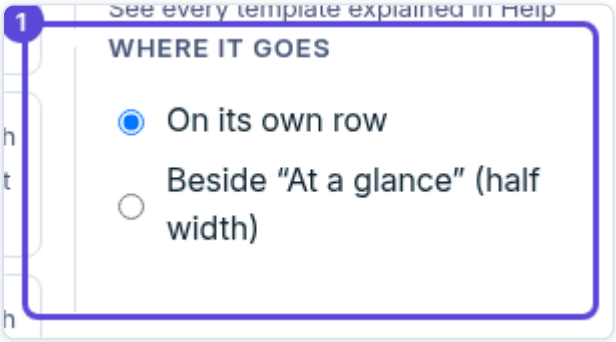


3. The **Add a section** box opens with the cursor in **Search templates**. On the left, pick a kind: **All templates**, **Text and pictures**, **Figures**, **Work items**, **Files and links**, **People and dates** or **Notes**. Or type a word to find a template by name.



4. Choose a template in the list, such as **Key figures, four** or **Callout**. `Up` and `Down` move through them. The box on the right says what the chosen one is for and what it **Holds**.

5. Under **Where it goes**, choose **On its own row**, or **Beside** the section above, which gives each of the two half the width. **Beside** is greyed out, with the reason under it, when the template cannot be half width or the section above is not on a row of its own.



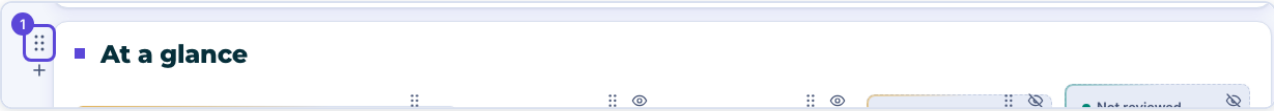
6. Press **Add section**, or press `Enter`. Press **Cancel**, or `Esc`, to close the box and add nothing.

> The new section sits below the one you chose, with its heading ready to rename. It starts empty, and an empty section is left out of what the client sees until you fill it. One **Undo** takes it away again.

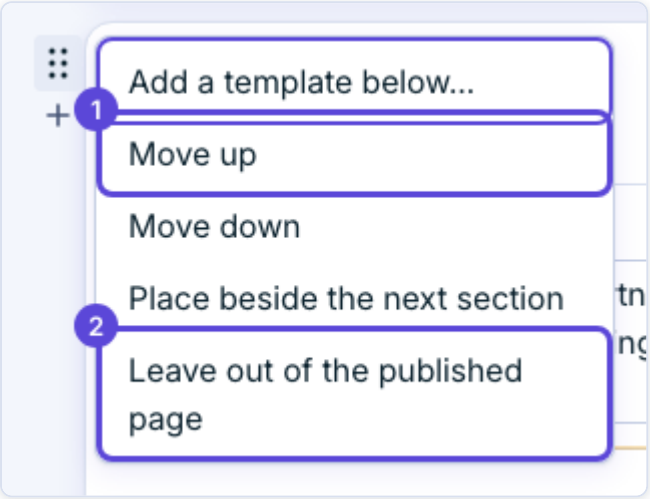
Move, hide and delete sections

Change the order of the report, put two sections side by side, or take parts out.

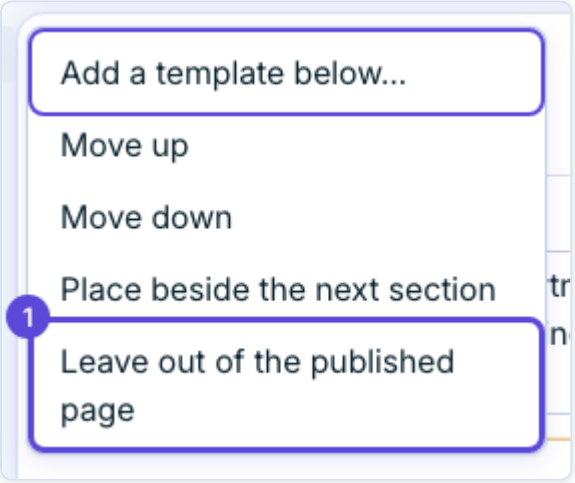
1. On the **Dashboard**, press **Edit**. Each section has a move button at the left of its card (in the margin on a wide window, inside the card on a narrow one). It is faint until you point at the section or tab to it.



2. To move a section, drag its move button and drop it. A line between two rows puts it on a row of its own. The cover stays at the top. Without a mouse, focus the button and press `Alt+Up` or `Alt+Down`.
3. Click the move button, or press `Enter` or `Space` on it, to open the section's menu.



4. To move one step, choose **Move up** or **Move down**. A choice that cannot be used is greyed out, with the reason under it.
5. To put a section beside another, choose **Place beside the next section**. Each takes half the width, and a row never holds more than two. For a section already in a pair the menu says **Full width** instead; choose it to give the section a row of its own.
6. To keep a section out of the client's copy, choose **Leave out of the published page**. It stays in Edit, greyed, with a small eye mark under its **+** and the tag **Left out of the published page**. Choose **Include in the published page** to bring it back.



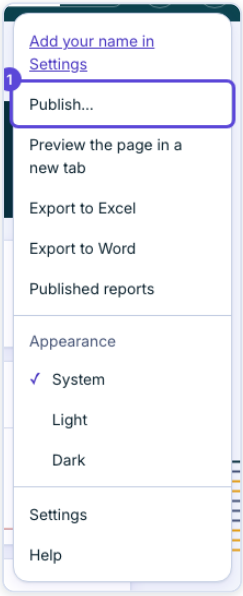
7. A text section, and the Needs from you section, also have **Delete section** in the menu. It removes the section from the report.

> Edit shows the sections in their new order, and the published page follows it. A section you left out is greyed in Edit and gone from View and from the published page. **Undo** puts back a move, a section left out or a section removed.

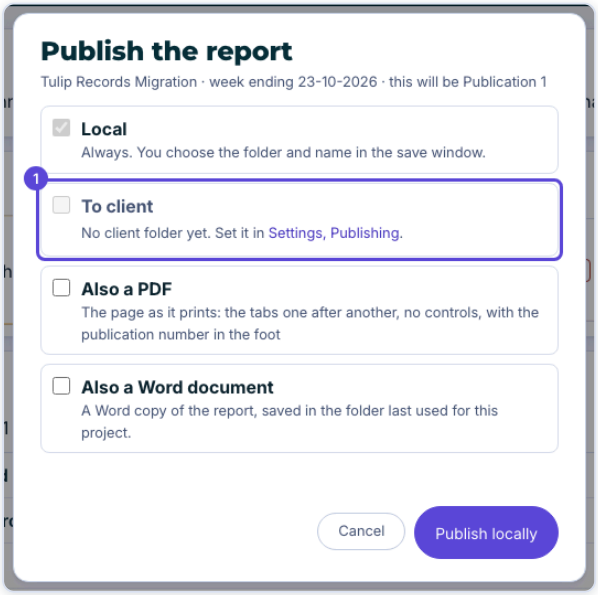
Publish to the client

Check the report, then save the finished copy locally and, if you choose, send it to the client.

1. To look first, press your profile circle and choose **Preview the page in a new tab**. It shows what the client will see, and nothing is saved.
2. Press your profile circle and choose **Publish…**. The box **Publish the report** opens. The line under its title gives the project, the week ending, the number this publication will have, such as this will be Publication 4, and when and where the last one went.



3. **Local** is always ticked, and the box says you choose the folder and name in the save window. Tick **To client** to copy it to the client folder as well. With no client folder set, that tick is off and a link takes you to Settings, Publishing to set one.



4. If you want them, tick **Also a PDF** (your browser's print box opens and you choose Save as PDF) and **Also a Word document** (a Word copy of the report, saved in the folder last used for this project).
5. With **To client** ticked, a line says the client will see the page, and the Word report if you ticked it, and only what is shown in View mode. A hidden section or a work item with its eye turned off is not included.
6. If a work item the client would see still has its placeholder title, such as New action, the box warns you with a count. It does not stop you. To fix it, press **Cancel**, rename the item or turn off its eye, and open **Publish…** again.
7. Press the button at the foot, which reads **Publish locally**, or **Publish and send to the client** when To client is ticked. A spinner shows while it works. If the file name is taken, the box asks what to do: **Add a number**, **Rename it** or, where it is allowed, **Overwrite the existing file**.
8. The button turns green and reads Published, with the publication number in brackets, such as Publication 4. Press it to close the box.

> The button shows a green tick and Published with its publication number. The saved page is the one the client sees, and the next publication gets the next number.

5 Ask clark, and change an item with words

Ask clark

Use ask clark to **Check this report**. It points out what looks wrong, such as an overdue action left off the page.

First, connect Claude or ChatGPT. ask clark needs one of them, signed in on your Mac.

1. In Settings, find the card that shows Claude and ChatGPT, each as **Connected** or **Not connected**.
2. Press **Connect** under the one you use if it says **Not connected**. No password is asked for: the Claude or ChatGPT command already signed in on this computer is the one used. If it is not signed in, the card says what to do.
3. Choose the model in **Model for ask clark**. If you choose a smaller one, the card asks first: **Use it anyway** or **Keep the model I have**.
4. To stop, press **Disconnect**. The card then says: Disconnected. You're still signed in to Claude or ChatGPT on this computer, but clark won't use it.

Claude counts as connected from the start when you are signed in to it. ChatGPT stays off until you press Connect.

Then ask:

1. Press `/` when you aren't typing in a box and the peek is closed. It opens down the right-hand side. Or press `Cmd+K` and choose **Ask about this project**.
2. Press **Check this report**, or another suggestion: **What is overdue?**, **Which risks are red?**, **What is the next milestone?**, **Summarise this week** or **Which use cases need attention?**. Or type your own question and press `Enter` (`Shift+Enter` for a new line).
3. An answer's IDs open the item; a milestone's name opens the milestone. A button in an answer makes a change, with **Undo**.

4. **New chat** starts again. **Close**, `Esc` or a click outside closes the panel.

> Where the words go. Connect Claude or ChatGPT for ask clark: the passages it sends leave this computer, go to the one you choose and count against that plan. No password or key is kept. The panel says it too. With Claude: Your question and the passages it needs go to Claude, which Anthropic runs, and are billed to the Claude account signed in on this computer. With ChatGPT: Your question and the passages it needs go to ChatGPT, which OpenAI runs, and are billed to the ChatGPT account signed in on this computer. If nothing is connected, the panel says: Nothing is connected in Settings. Connect Claude or ChatGPT there to use this.

- clark has no sign-in of its own. The sign-in is the one you already have for Claude or ChatGPT on this Mac.
- Nothing is sent until you ask a question. Asking is on from the first start. To turn it off, open Settings, find **Asking** and press **Turn off asking**. While it is off, the panel says: Asking is off. Turn it on in Settings.
- It works from this project's data and the source folders listed in Settings. It never reads mail, Teams or calendars.
- It only reads: it never changes a file. Parts of the files in these folders can be sent to the one you connected, when they help answer a question.
- Passwords and keys: a question, or a passage from a source folder, that looks like a password or a key is not sent.

Change an item with words (Sneak peek)

Change a work item by typing what should change.

1. In Edit, with a work item open in the peek, press `/` twice quickly (when you aren't typing in a box), or press the sparkle at the top, "Change an item with words". A milestone has no Sneak peek.
2. Type the change, for example "move to Friday, owner Jo, high priority". It understands the due date, the owner, the priority and the status.
3. Under the box, each change shows as a line: the field, what it is now, an arrow and what it will be.
4. Press `Enter` to make the changes shown, as one step. `Shift+Enter` makes them and keeps the box open. `Esc` closes it. The fields that changed flash for a moment, and the message has **Undo**.

> A change that closes or cancels an item, or makes a decision, asks you to confirm first. Sneak peek reads your words with plain code on your Mac: it does not need ask clark, and it sends nothing to Claude, ChatGPT or anywhere else.

6 Where your data lives

Your data stays on your computer, in ~/Library/Application Support/clark/. That folder holds your database (clark.db), clark's safety copies (in a backups folder beside it) and a log file.

- Keep it out of OneDrive, Dropbox and any other synced folder. They can damage a database that is open.
- Safety copies are made before every Undo, before every Excel import and once a day. The newest 14 of each kind are kept. Settings › Backups lists them and puts one back.

7 If something goes wrong



If clark says it did not start, it names a log file (server.log in the data folder). Do not share your database or any real client information.

If clark will not start, close it and type bash clark.command restore in Terminal, in the clark folder, to see your safety copies.

```
bash clark.command restore
```

If it says nothing was started because clark is already open in another Terminal window, or another program is using the connection it needs, close that Terminal window or program, then double-click clark.command again.

If it says port 8766 is already used, another clark is open: close it, or stop it with the command in step 5 of the Docker steps, then try again. If it says it cannot connect to Docker, Docker Desktop is not running yet.

Made a mistake? Every change saves on its own, and the message at the foot of the page offers Undo.